

Garlicky White Bean & Kale Stew with Lemon

This lemony kale and white bean stew offers bright, hearty, and comforting flavors all in one pot. Tender carrots, onion and lacinato kale simmer with creamy cannellini beans, some of which are mashed to thicken the broth. A sprinkle of Parmesan and parsley adds a fresh zesty finish. Serve with crusty bread on the side for a nourishing bowl that feels just right for chilly nights.

By **Carolyn Malcoun** | Published on November 26, 2025

 Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

Active Time: 45 mins

Total Time: 45 mins

Servings: 4

Nutrition Profile:

Anti-Inflammatory Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free High-Calcium Bone Health Weight Loss Diabetes-Friendly Nut-Free Healthy Pregnancy Healthy Aging Healthy Immunity Soy-Free High-Fiber Healthy Cholesterol Vegetarian High-Protein Egg-Free Gluten-Free Low-Calorie

Ingredients

- 2 tablespoons extra-virgin olive oil plus 4 teaspoons, divided
- 2 medium carrots, peeled and chopped (about 1½ cups)
- 1 small yellow onion, chopped (about 1 cup)
- ¾ teaspoon salt, divided
- 1 medium bunch lacinato kale (about 12 ounces), stemmed and chopped (about 8 cups)
- 6 medium cloves garlic, finely chopped (2 tablespoons)
- ½ teaspoon crushed red pepper
- 3 cups reduced-sodium vegetable broth, divided
- 2 (15-ounce) cans no-salt-added cannellini beans, rinsed, divided
- 1 teaspoon grated lemon zest
- 2 tablespoons lemon juice, divided
- ¼ cup finely grated Parmesan cheese (1 ounce)
- 2 tablespoons chopped fresh flat-leaf parsley

Directions

Step 1

Heat 2 tablespoons oil in a small Dutch oven over medium-high heat. Add chopped carrots, chopped onion and ¼ teaspoon salt; cook, stirring occasionally, until slightly softened, about 6 minutes. Add chopped kale, chopped garlic and ½ teaspoon crushed red pepper; cook, stirring often, until the kale is wilted, about 2 minutes. Add 1½ cups broth; cook, stirring occasionally, until slightly reduced, about 5 minutes. Stir in the remaining 1½ cups broth and ½ teaspoon salt. Continue cooking until the kale is tender, about 5 minutes.

Step 2

Meanwhile, place half of the rinsed beans in a small bowl; using a fork, mash until mostly smooth.

Step 3

Stir the mashed beans and the remaining whole beans into the stew. Bring to a lively simmer over medium-high heat. Simmer, stirring occasionally, until the broth thickens slightly, about 4 minutes. Stir in 2 tablespoons lemon juice. Remove from heat.

Step 4

In a small bowl, combine ¼ cup Parmesan, 2 tablespoons parsley and 1 teaspoon lemon zest. Divide the stew among 4 shallow bowls. Top each serving with the Parmesan mixture and drizzle with the remaining 4 teaspoons oil (1 teaspoon per bowl).

Frequently Asked Questions

What's the purpose of cooking down the broth?

Cooking the kale while the broth reduces helps infuse the greens with flavor and creates a concentrated base.

Can I use another green instead of kale?

Absolutely! We found that lacinato (aka Tuscan) kale adds a delightful texture to this recipe. However, curly kale, which is more widely available, can also be used. You can substitute other leafy greens if you want, such as spinach, Swiss chard, collard greens or mustard greens. In fact, any leafy green that can withstand simmering and contributes texture and nutrients will work well. Additionally, consider adding fennel or celery for some extra vegetables.

What makes this stew thick and creamy without cream?

When developing this recipe, we opted for a clever method to thicken the stew without adding cream. Instead, we mashed some of the beans and added them to the pot. This technique thickens the broth while keeping the stew creamy.

How should I store and reheat leftovers?

Store the stew in an airtight container in the refrigerator, where it will remain fresh for up to 4 days. The flavors will meld and taste even better on the second day. Heat the stew in the microwave in 1-minute bursts or on the stovetop over medium heat (making sure it doesn't boil) until it reaches the desired temperature.

For longer storage, you can freeze the leftovers for up to 2 months. To enjoy, simply thaw overnight in the refrigerator and heat gently with a splash of broth. (Note: If double-batching the recipe to freeze, you may want to leave out the kale until reheating for better color and texture, which can get depleted when frozen and thawed.)

What should I serve with Garlicky White Bean & Kale Stew with Lemon?



Serve the stew with crusty bread for dipping. For a lighter meal, you can pair it with a simple green salad or enjoy it alongside one of our favorite chilly-weather favorites, such as Spinach & Warm Mushroom Salad, Balsamic Berry Vinaigrette Winter Salad or Winter Salad with Toasted Walnuts.

Recipe developed by Marianne Williams

EatingWell.com, November 2025

Nutrition Facts

Per serving: **Serving Size about 1¼ cups** 428 calories; total fat 15g; saturated fat 3g; cholesterol 6mg; sodium 700mg; total carbohydrate 58g; dietary fiber 14g; total sugars 7g; added sugars 0g; protein 20g; vitamin c 51mg; calcium 313mg; iron 7mg; potassium 1415mg

Additional reporting by Sarah Pflugrad, Ph.D., RDN, CSCS and Linda Frahm

Additional reporting by Sarah Pflugrad, Ph.D., RDN, CSCS and Linda Frahm

Explore more:

[Healthy Recipes](#)[Ingredient](#)[Beans](#)

Was this page helpful?

